

Story

Sudan: Multinationals accused of sourcing conflict gold linked to war financing; incl. cos. responses & non-responses



Since the outbreak of war in Sudan in April 2023, gold has become the central pillar of war finance. As the formal export system collapsed and smuggling networks expanded across borders, gold emerged as the primary source of foreign currency for the warring parties. Official and international reports estimate that military actors generate millions of dollars per day from gold-related activities, reinforcing a parallel economy that prolongs the conflict and weakens state institutions.

In 2024, the Sudan Gold Refinery in Khartoum (Smelter ID: CID002567) continued to appear within global supply-chain reporting frameworks, including in the Volkswagen Group's 2024 Responsible Raw Materials Report, an annual corporate disclosure outlining the company's due-diligence efforts to identify and manage risks in its raw-material supply chains. This occurred despite the refinery having been seized by the Rapid Support Forces (RSF) in May 2023 and subsequently rendered non-operational. Satellite imagery from 2023–2025 confirms progressive destruction of infrastructure and complete cessation of industrial activity.

In April, the Business and Human Rights Centre invited all companies to respond. Only Mitsubishi and Microchip replied. We attempted to contact Keyence, Lexmark, and Ricoh but were unable to reach any of them.

Company Responses